

The job simulation on The Forage that I chose to complete was Bank of America's Investment Banking Simulation. This simulation took me around 5 hours to complete but it was very well tied into the career I plan on working in, in the future. The first module of this simulation provided a basic overview of how to construct a SWOT analysis after understanding key historical performance and results in a company's 10-K report. The SWOT analysis section of this module was pretty easy and nothing new to me, but when they incorporated searching through the 10K of a company to find the information you need, it made me think about how I can convert multiple pages of company information into 2-3 bullet points on a slide show. What I really liked about this simulation is that throughout all the modules, after you submit the work you did, it shows you the answer that Bank of America was looking for, so you can see how your work compares to that of an associate. This feature really helped me learn how to write like a professional in the field and come up with a formal tone throughout my projects. In one of the last modules, my draft ended up sounding almost identical to the "solution," which showed the real-time growth in my abilities as I went through the simulation.

Module 2 of this simulation dove into aspects that investment bankers consider when examining potential M&A deals and methods for raising Capital. For this module, I started by examining the financial and current trends they're exhibiting. Two of the standout companies were Nintendo and Sony. After doing a deep dive into all the listed companies, I was tasked with answering some goal- and finance-based quiz questions to determine the best M&A option for Webflix. This unit taught me how to start looking at potential M&A deals and determine if it would be in the best interest of the company to pursue the acquisition or pass up on the opportunity.

Module 3 of this job simulation combined the previous modules with Nintendo's 10K and the chosen M&A deal for Webflix to start crafting a DCF to determine the present value of Nintendo Corporation. After going through a brief 3-minute introduction to what a DCF model is, how you can construct a detailed and accurate one. Over the summer, I completed a virtual externship that focused on DCF valuations, so most of the content covered wasn't new to me, but it served as a good refresher on a very important skill in Investment Banking. The simulation provided me with an Excel template to complete the DCF because starting from scratch would most likely take a lot longer than the predicted 5-hour time commitment. The biggest obstacle in this part of the simulation was finding all of the assumptions needed for the DCF formulas to work, which included the Revenue Growth, EBITDA, EBITDA margin, D&A, WACC, and the terminal multiple. One thing that I did not like about the job simulation is that it did not go into detail about what each of those assumptions does; it kind of just told you this is what they are, and you have to go apply them in the DCF template. This led me to Google most of the assumptions and what their formulas were, so in the end, I still did end up learning, but I wish it had been more incorporated into the actual simulation. After the DCF sheet was constructed the next part was to make a sensitivity table using the data analytics feature in Excel, which confused me because again it did not provide clear instructions on how to do so, which caused me to use Claude, built into Excel, to formulate and walk me through how to conduct the

sensitivity and shareholder price table. I learned how important it is to have both of these tables to calculate the minimum and maximum valuation of Nintendo and its Share price, dependent on movements in the WACC and Terminal Multiple. This was definitely my favorite module so far because it felt like I was finally doing the technical Excel work that I am the most interested in, rather than just analysis and formal writing exercises, which I realize are just as important as the technical work. The final step of this module was to write a team email addressing the DCF findings and your opinions on whether to continue or drop talks of a potential M&A deal between Nintendo and Webflix.

The fourth module of this simulation focused on creating professional business PowerPoint presentations to present the findings about Nintendo's operations and valuations from the conducted DCF. Prior to this experience, I honestly had no idea what a company overview and report-based PowerPoint should look like, and I was a bit surprised when I saw the example provided. Going into it, I expected the presentation to be pretty much only charts with minimal bullet points, but that is not what it was at all. It contained a lot of graphics related to the general company, such as their logo and some of the most well-known products. A useful skill I learned from this module was how to create effective charts in Excel for a presentation. The two charts I was tasked with making were one comparing revenue and EBITDA per year, showing EBITDA as a line chart and Revenue in bar format, which was interesting to figure out how to do in Excel. The second chart was a pie chart showing sales by region, which was much simpler but still a challenge to make it visually appealing.

The fifth and final module of this job simulation focused on building long-term Relationships with clients, making professional calls, and leaving up-to-standard voicemails. To practice voice message skills, I was given a scenario and tasked with writing a short 30 second- 1 minute script posing as an MD at Bank of America. To make sure I really felt comfortable with this exercise, I ended up doing a few voice recordings to see the flow of my script and how I would approach reading it with a proper tone. Although this wasn't a required part of the module, I still think it helped me really solidify these concepts. I wish I had some of these skills when working my part-time job over the summer, because I was tasked with making sales/outreach calls as a front desk worker at a local community gym, and I had no idea how to even approach these, as that wasn't in the list of tasks that I had been working there the past 3 years, but the skills from this module definitely would have translated perfectly into my daily job.

After completing all the modules for Bank of America's Investment Banking Job simulation, I really do feel like I learned a lot, and I am glad I didn't take the easy way out by choosing a shorter simulation and not letting that 5-6 hour time estimate scare me. This experience is definitely something I could bring up in potential investment banking interviews to demonstrate interest and knowledge in the field, hopefully giving me a leg up against other students applying for the same role.